

tern, goes a long way towards convincing people about something. Brands often use this to influence consumers by establishing a false pattern. “In 2015 we released the amazing abc, in 2016 we followed up with an equally brilliant pqr, and now we in 2017 we have the xyz which is going to change...”

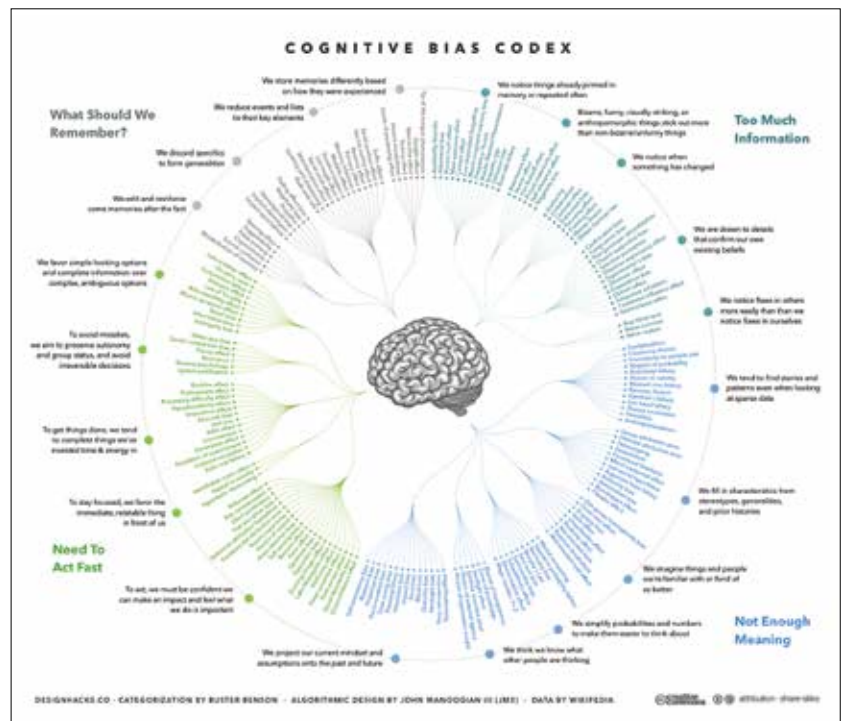
3. GROUPTHINK

Humans are a social species. We evolved in groups and largely depended on the ‘wisdom of the pack’ as a means to survive. Think about the last time you were at a railway ticket counter. Our instinct, strangely, is to join the bigger line. The hard coded algorithm in our brain doesn’t wait to make a logical choice here (which is shorter line = quicker ticket), instead it assumes that if the group is clustered around a particular ticket window, it must be better. Inversely, there must be something wrong with other ticket window.

This is why even today we look at nonconformists with suspicion. We’re programmed to believe going with the crowd works. Brands like Apple have realised this long ago. The large scale flashy keynotes, the cult-like appeal of a figurehead all contribute to exploit the herd mentality that is inherent within us. Even those who call them sheeple are ironically conforming to a different groupthink, but a groupthink nonetheless.

4. ASSOCIATION THROUGH CORRELATION

As much as we’d like to believe we are unique as individuals, humans are similar to each other in a lot of aspects; even in terms of the kinds of experiences they’ve had in their lives. Take for example things like summer vacations, the childhood joy of kicking around a ball with your mates, cycling downhill, the imagery and smells associated with rain, pictures of mountains – these are things that are universally liked and remembered. Further, we are even conditioned to have pleasant associations with those things. Like Pavlov’s dogs we are quick to get triggered when such imagery is shown to us. This is the reason why car manufacturers often use a certain kind of provocative imagery to market their cars. Our lizard brain (simple as it is) makes that instant as-



The cognitive biases codex, organises logical fallacies into four large categories: biases that arise from too much information, not enough meaning, the need to act quickly, and the limits of memory. Be sure to follow this link and zoom in for the details: <http://dgit.in/mindtricks>

sociation. Marketers can successfully use images of open fields, children playing etc to sort of hack your mind or program you into having the desired results.

5. FALSE SENSE OF SCARCITY

Perhaps the oldest trick in the book, this method of fooling you tries to prey on multiple fallacies in our thinking. They way our minds have evolved, we aren’t too good at estimating probabilistic outcomes. So what marketers do is create a sense of urgency coupled with an uncertainty for the future. The future today is far more certain than it was when evolutionary processes were shaping our day-to-day habits. Markets will keep coming up with seemingly attractive “just for you”, “limited stock”, and “one time only” offers. Just as our very own Booman fell for one of these when going for the Daydream View (page 71),

Check out a very related bias called the “Monte Carlo fallacy” in which people have a tendency to think that future probabilities are altered by past events. No wonder it’s called the gambler’s fallacy: <http://dgit.in/gmbfal>

so will you, no matter how logical you think you are. Hyperbolic discounting is a legit scientific term, look it up. It basically means our brains are hard-wired to pick the bird in hand over the two in the bush. Those who are trying to sell you things will always try to obscure the two in the bush and make the bird in hand appear to be more scarce and juicy all at once.

Apart from the ways listed above, there are literally dozen of such exploits avail-

able that can make us part with our hard-earned moola. Effects and biases such as the sunk cost fallacy, money illusion, status anxiety, irrational escalation of commitment are just some of them. We urge you to look these up and go down this fascinating rabbit hole. For when you emerge from the other end, you’ll be much smarter (or at least you can tell yourself that). 